

BEFORE



PREDYNASTIC
GRAVE GOODS

The ancient Egyptians believed in many gods, and in an afterlife. Various gods rose to prominence and then faded again.

LIFE AFTER DEATH

Items found in graves from predynastic Egypt (before c. 3100 BCE) suggest that, even then, Egyptians performed death-related rituals.

THE ORIGINS OF OSIRIS

Belief in Osiris is thought to have begun in the Nile Delta region and probably developed from the local god of a place called Busiris. Initially, Osiris may have been a **god of agriculture**, linked with fertility and the afterlife. He gained popularity throughout Egypt and by the middle of the Old Kingdom **◀56–57**, c. 2400 BCE, had become a dominant figure, associated with death and the **resurrection of the ruler**.

RIVALRY WITH RA

Before Osiris, the cult of Ra (or Re), god of the Sun and bringer of life, held center stage. Ra is depicted with a falcon's head, on which is carried the sun.

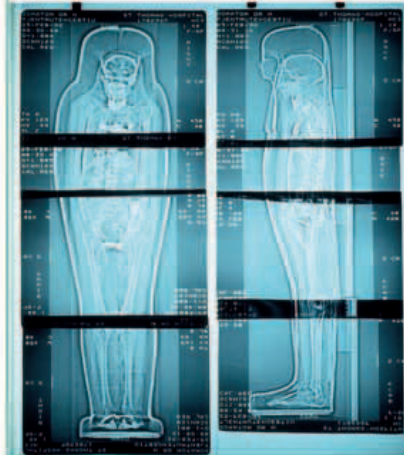


RA, THE
SUN-GOD

HOW WE KNOW

INVESTIGATING MUMMIES

In the 5th–1st century BCE, historians such as the Greeks Herodotus and Diodorus Siculus provided the first reliable data on mummies. Since then, studying them has become an increasingly sophisticated science. DNA is analyzed (see p.465), and the mummy checked for the presence of diseases, to reveal more about its identity and the Egyptian way of life. Imaging techniques, such as X-rays and CAT-scans (below), can reveal a great deal without causing permanent damage.



For the ancient Egyptians, the need and desire to please their gods were driving forces that influenced most aspects of their lives. They believed that the god Osiris judged them on the lives they had led and that those who had lived “good lives” would attain a happy eternity alongside the gods. He was thought to preside over their complex burial rituals, including embalming and mummification (see opposite), which they devised to ensure a passage through the underworld to an afterlife.

Osiris's cult continued to develop during the Old Kingdom (c. 2686–2181 BCE). People came to believe that the pharaohs, Egypt's leaders, were reborn as Osiris after death. This powerful link to the Egyptians' belief in kings as gods was reflected in the “rebirth” elements of their burial rituals.

Cult of the people

After the collapse of the Old Kingdom (see pp.56–57), the popularity of the Osiris cult was assisted by the shift in government dynamics.

With the pharaoh no longer an all-powerful figure, local officials gained in importance. In this slightly more democratic climate, the burial rites and the right to rebirth, once strictly confined to the pharaohs, were increasingly extended to ordinary Egyptians. At the height of Osiris's popularity, even mere mortals were believed to connect with the god at



Osiris figurine

The god was traditionally portrayed partly bandaged, as if being mummified.

His grandfather was Ra (see BEFORE) and his brother was Set, god of chaos. Osiris was husband (and brother) of Isis, a protective and magical goddess, and father of Horus, who was god of the sky and protector of the ruler of Egypt. Myth also told that the jealous and vengeful Set trapped Osiris in a coffinlike chest and threw it in the Nile River, then took his brother's position as king. Isis found and hid the body of her beloved husband, only for Set to discover it and tear it apart, scattering the pieces. It was said that Isis lovingly sought out all the remains and buried them where she found them (so aiding the spread of the cult). His body was then reassembled and bound with bandages, and he so became the first mummy. Isis revived Osiris by magic, and he traveled to the underworld to become king of the dead.

A matter of life and death

From these myths it is clear that the Egyptians' burial practices, particularly mummification and embalming, were a reflection of

Osiris' own sufferings and the journey his soul made to the afterlife. Ideas about the soul and spirit were central to burial practices, and to beliefs in general. The Egyptians came to believe that each human being consisted not only of a physical body, but also of three spiritual parts. First, the *ka*, was part of a kind of “soul” and the essential life-force—a person's

A jury of 12 gods sits in judgment of the deceased. They pronounce their decision in a chamber often referred to as the “hall of Ma'at.”



The deceased, Any, followed by his wife, walks into the “court,” ready for the weighing of his heart and judgment by the jury of gods above.

The Realm of Osiris

The growth of the cult of Osiris, king of the dead, was immensely important to the ancient Egyptians. Osiris gradually became the dominant figure among a cast of potentially vengeful gods. These gods had strong moral codes, so living a good and honest life was vital if you were to gain eternity.

their death (this identification with Osiris was considered essential to reach eternal afterlife). Previously, such an honor was confined to their kings.

Family drama

Despite his growing importance, Osiris remained part of a broad and complex family of divine characters, each with a vital role to play in the Egyptian belief system. Tradition held that Osiris was the son of Geb, god of the earth, and Nut, goddess of the sky, and that he was once king of Upper Egypt.

“double.” The *ba* formed another part of the “soul” and, in modern terms, an individual's personality. Finally, the *akh* was the form in which a deceased person existed in the afterlife, when the *ka* and *ba* were reunited.

It was typically believed that the *ka* and *ba* were released from the body at death and needed to find each other again in the afterlife in order to create a happy, eternal *akh*. The released *ka* returned to the dead body, feeding off it to stay alive. If the body was decayed or unrecognizable, the *ka* might not be

“Homage to thee, Osiris, lord of eternity, king of gods, whose names are manifold.”

THE EGYPTIAN BOOK OF THE DEAD, 1240 BCE